

demands more space for itself. The build quality is reassuring, and our only crib is that its pure white body is an open invitation to stains.

A quirk with the Brother 3240C is that the USB cable plugs in *inside* the printer: you need to open the cover that exposes the cartridges and then plug the cable in, guiding it along a narrow recess. There simply is not enough room to comfortably accommodate the ferrite core that comes at the end of most cables. This holds good for all the Brother MFDs across all the categories.

Our Conclusion

Good print quality is essential, and HP's Officejet 4355 All-in-One and Brother's MFC-3240C scored well on that front. Between these two, the 4355 with its rich feature set and compact form rightfully takes the *Digit Best Buy Gold* award. Losing this position by a whisker is the Brother MFC-3240C, which wins the *Digit Best Buy Silver* award.

FOR OFFICE USE: PHOTO MFDS UP TO RS 10,000

Here you will find MFDs that boast of photo-printing capability and do not cost a bomb either. These are suitable for both the home and SoHo segments. Printing the occasional photo along with the usual black-and-whites at home,

and volume printing for the SoHo user—these units are suited to both scenarios.

Performance

The Brother DCP-115C, at a very affordable Rs 4,490, marks the entry point to this category. Its print quality looks acceptable from a distance, but once you bring it under even a low-powered magnifying glass, faint lines show up in the black text. At the Fast setting, these lines are easily apparent to the eye. You have to choose the Fine quality setting in order to get rid of them.

The DCP-115C takes 17 seconds for the first print—not great news in an office setting. In Normal mode, the time taken was 26 seconds, the highest in the category. A full A4 photo printout generated some bands in the print, which doesn't speak too well for uniformity. At a distance, though, the print can pass off as satisfactory.

The copier function is just about passable, with black as well as colours appearing washed out. The DCP-115C is cheap, but these are the compromises you need to make if you are on a tight budget.



HP Officejet 5610 All-in-One

How We Tested

The Test Bed

Our test bed for the Inkjet MFD tests comprised an Intel Pentium 4 3.6 GHz processor, an Intel 925XCV motherboard with 1 GB of Micron 533 MHz DDR2 RAM, an NVIDIA GeForce 7600 graphics card, and a 120 GB 7200 rpm ATA IV Seagate Barracuda hard disk. We used Windows XP with SP1 as the OS. The system was loaded with all the latest chipset and graphics drivers as well as the latest version of DirectX.

We used the following media:

Text/combi-document printouts: 100 g/sm paper from Berga (A4 size)

Photo printouts: 270 g/sm glossy photo paper from Novajet (A4 size)

We divided the MFDs into three categories. The non-photo printers comprised the Home category. The Photo MFDs were categorised based on price. Those below Rs 10,000 came under the Office category, and the rest under the Professional category. MFDs that did not fit in any category, or were priced too high, are given special mentions.

Features

Various features such as PictBridge, memory card readers, input/output tray capacity, and maximum print and scan resolution were noted. For the scanner part, the maximum scan resolution, bit depth, scanner type, ADF presence, etc. were noted and rated. For the copier aspect, the ability to work as a standalone device, the maximum number of pages that can be printed in multi-copy mode, reduction or enlarging a copy, and so on, were noted. Obviously, most of these features were standard on the higher-end MFDs.

The Printer Tests

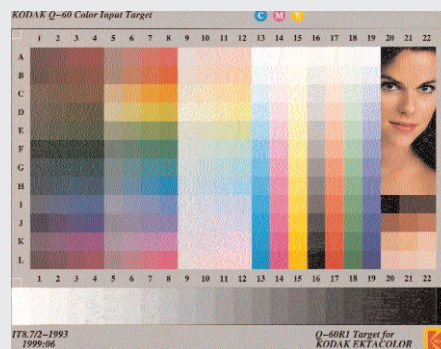
We used a text document to test the raw print speeds of the printer part of the MFDs. To test the ability of the MFDs to handle the various aspects of a regular document, we created a combi-document with black text interspersed with graphs and images. The quality settings used were Draft and Normal for text, Normal and Best for combi-document (refer to the combi document snapshot in the printer test), and Best for photo. We clocked the time taken in each case, and analysed the print quality. The final test for the printers was the photo test, where we used 270 g/sm Novajet Glossy Photo Paper to print an A4 image. We used the highest available quality settings here.

The Scanner Tests

We tested the scanners for speed using an average of five previews of an A4 size image. This was done with the scanner fresh out of the box, in order to incorporate the warm-up time. We imported the same A4 size image at 150 dpi and 600 dpi in Adobe Photoshop, and scanned a full text document in B&W mode at 200 dpi. The scanner then underwent a test to determine its colour differentiating abilities using a Kodak IT8 card with different shades of colour—each a little different from the preceding one. Next, we tested using the resolution chart. This is a chart with five boxes consisting of parallel lines very close to each other, each with the lines packed more densely than in the preceding box. We scanned the resolution chart at 300 dpi. This test checked whether the scanner could scan and differentiate between the parallel lines in the chart, and gave us a measure of the

scanner's capability to capture minute details.

Finally, we did an OCR test to check the scanner's ability to differentiate light and dark areas: a print article was scanned into the trial version of ABBYY Fine Reader Pro 8.0 PE, and scanned for wrongly-interpreted letters. We then counted the number of misinterpreted characters.



The Kodak IT8 sheet used to test scanning quality

The Copier Tests

We copied the text document in black and white, and the combi-document in colour, and rated the MFDs on their speed and print quality.

The Awards

The scores from Features, Performance, and Price were given category-relevant importance. An overall score out of 100 was calculated. The product that scores the highest here was adjudged the winner of the *Digit Best Buy Gold* award for the category. The second-highest scorer gets the *Digit Best Buy Silver* award for the category.